

an antivirus perspective, false negatives probably seem more serious than false positives, but both are undesirable.

Fast Infector

When programs infected with common file infectors are run, the virus code usually gets control first. It then checks it has not already gone resident, copies itself into memory, and hooks a system interrupt or event handler associated with the host platform's 'load and execute' function. When that function is subsequently called, the virus' infection routine runs, checking whether the program that is about to run has been infected already, and if not, infects it.

Mass Mailer, Fast Mailer

A virus that distributes itself via e-mail to multiple addressees at once is known as a mass mailer.

FAT, File Allocation Table

A crucial part of the standard file systems employed in all versions of DOS and Windows 9x. The FAT records the chaining of disk clusters and the final cluster in a file. A file's first cluster is stored in its directory entry and also acts as an offset into the FAT's chaining table so the rest of the file can be located.

Field Sample, Field Virus, In the Field

Sometimes viruses are said to be 'in the field' or 'reported from the field'. This may be loose usage of the term, or it may be to draw the distinction between viruses that have been seen in a small number of real-world infection incidents ('in the field') and those that have reached the top half of the WildList ('In the Wild').

File Infector

These are viruses that attach themselves to (or replace; see Companion Virus) .COM and .EXE files, although in some cases they will infect files with other extensions such as .SYS, .DRV, .BIN, .OVL, .CPL, .DLL, .SCR and others. The most common file viruses are resident viruses, loading into memory at the time the first copy is run, and taking clandestine control of the computer. Such viruses